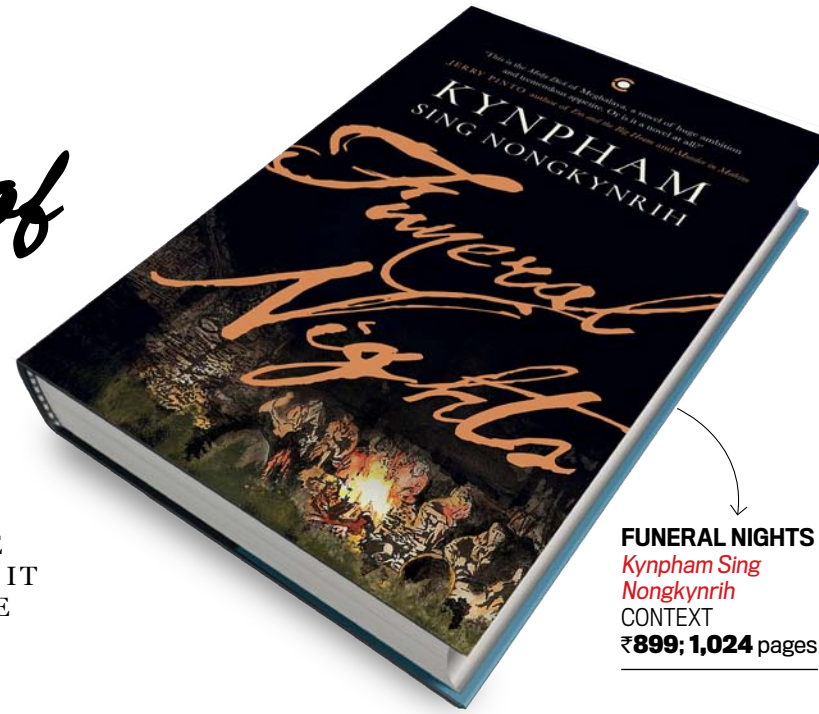
BOOKS

Matters of Life and Death

THE STORIES OF DEATH THAT CHARACTERS SHARE IN THIS 1,000-PAGE BOOK ARE RIVETING, BUT WHAT MAKES IT TRULY UNPUTDOWNABLE ARE THE VITAL CONNECTIONS IT DRAWS TO DAILY LIFE



FUNERAL NIGHTS
Kynpham Sing Nongkynrih
CONTEXT
₹899; 1,024 pages

ON MY BRUISED AND BATTERED copy of Vikram Seth's '90s classic *A Suitable Boy*, there are numerous blurbs, but one has stuck through multiple rereads: "Not so much postmodern as pre-modern." It's a subtle compliment, for it draws attention to certain narrative traits found in medieval literature: artful digression, allusive exaggeration, collective wisdom, the gradual concatenation of stories-upon-stories. All of these also happen to be true for Kynpham Sing Nongkynrih's *Funeral Nights*, a 1,000-page doorstopper recently published by Context.

Over a decade in the making, *Funeral Nights* is structured along the lines of pre-modern texts like Chaucer's *The Canterbury Tales*: travellers converge at a certain symbolic location and exchange tales; gradually, these tales 'interact' and grow to become more than the sum of their parts. In *Funeral Nights*, this convergence is brought about thanks to Ka Phor Sorat, the feast of the dead, a six-day funeral ritual observed by the Lyngngams (a Khasi sub-tribe).

In **FUNERAL NIGHTS**, characters trade stories to explain the idiosyncrasies of their various family traditions around funerals

Death is never far away from the 'action' in this book. Characters trade stories about death at the drop of a hat, and often continue these stories to explain the idiosyncrasies of their various family traditions around funerals. Like this passage, deep into the novel's second half, describing a unique 'leave-taking' ceremony: "Victor told me the ceremony was called *kaikong*, literally, 'visiting houses'. Before the body could be taken to the cremation hill, he explained, it had to be carried to the houses of the maternal and paternal relations of the deceased as a kind of leave-taking. (...) Incongruously, the visit reminded me of a politician on a door-to-door visit."

As you can surmise, the novel's dominant tonality is 'drily funny', although the second half, especially, shows off an impressive range of voices and styles.

It's tempting to paint *Funeral Nights* as a text about Khasi identity, an act of literary and cultural assertion. But that would be doing the author a disservice, for *Funeral Nights* is so much more: it's just as much about existential doubt, for instance. Questions like, 'Do I know my own culture?' or 'How justified is calling so-and-so person an "outsider" when my own status is liminal at best?' These are vitally important questions today, when the headlines are dominated by mass disenfranchisement and widespread 'Othering'. For this, and scores of other reasons, *Funeral Nights* is both astute and timely. Pile-drive through it in two weeks or ruminate across several months—but make sure you read one of the best novels of the year gone by. ■

–Aditya Mani Jha